

AT THE READY
A police commando stands guard near the Red Fort in Delhi

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CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

Crime has increased but the rate of chargesheeting and conviction for IPC cases hasn't kept pace

candid note prepared by Union home ministry after 2013, summarising the state of policing in independent India, stated: "Police reforms have been on the agenda of governments almost since independence, but...the police is seen as selectively efficient, unsympathetic to the underprivileged. It is further accused of politicisation and criminalisation. One needs to note that the basic framework for policing in India was made in 1861, with little changes thereafter, whereas society has undergone dramatic changes...."

In a landmark judgment, the Supreme Court in September 2006 had directed all states and Union territories to bring in police reforms and implement measures to ensure that the police could function without political interference. Yet little action has been taken, while the political nature of the police forces has reached new heights, with police teams of different states clashing with each other.

Expenditure on the police has increased over 4,000 times since Independence, but most of the expenses are on salaries and maintenance. Even now, the Centre spends only two per cent of its total police budget on modernisation of the forces. Policing is a state subject, yet the states collectively spend only one per cent of their police expenditure on modernisation. With 21 per cent posts lying vacant, there is a marginal improvement in the number of police personnel for every 100,000 people—from 131 in 1951 to 194 now. The police in India certainly need political patronage—but of a different kind—to perform better: a big push in reforms and strengthening infrastructure. ■

ZERO ACTION

Multiple committees and commissions have been formed to recommend actions for police reforms. But little has been done. Here are some of the top reports:

- **EIGHT REPORTS** by National Police Commission, 1978-1982
- **PADMANABHAIAH COMMITTEE** on restructuring of police, 2000
- **MALIMATH COMMITTEE** on reforms in Criminal Justice System, 2002-03
- **SUPREME COURT** directives to states for police reforms, 1996
- **RIBEIRO COMMITTEE** constituted in 1998, to review the actions taken on Supreme Court directives
- **11 STATE COMMISSIONS** have been formed to review the work of police forces